



Foreword

There is no shortage of platitudes purporting to cover women's role in human history: "Women hold up half the sky." "Well-behaved women rarely make history." And perhaps most maddening, "Behind every great man is a great woman." They all reduce women's roles to bit parts, footnotes, or curiosities. So, while it might seem absurd to devote just one book (even a book as impressive as this one) to the entire history of half the world's population, I am delighted to read a history book in which women get all the starring roles.

A more optimistic adage for the contemporary women's movement is gaining ground: "The future is female." But the past is female, too. When we neglect women's stories, we aren't only depriving women and girls (and boys) of role models and empowering lessons; we are getting history wrong. The notion that women haven't been agents of historical change is, among many other objections, mathematically impossible. I'm not talking about the power-behind-the-throne model, the acknowledgment that Abigail Adams may have

influenced her husband's revolutionary thinking, or Zelda Fitzgerald inspired F. Scott's best lines. I'm talking about actual history made by women—in many cases for women.

As the centennial of the suffrage movement's victory in winning voting rights for American women approaches, historians are writing books and articles highlighting the incredible stories of the women who fought for this goal. Pioneers like Susan B. Anthony and Elizabeth Cady Stanton get their due, of course, but now we are also hearing about the women who saw the fight through to the end: Alice Paul, Lucy Burns, Dora Lewis, and Carrie Chapman Catt, among many others. These women raised money; staged protest marches; created complex grassroots organizations; lobbied Congress tirelessly; managed press and PR operations; invented the idea of picketing the White House; were arrested, beaten, and force-fed; and inspired countless activists around the world. They did everything short of actually passing and ratifying the 19th Amendment, the one step they could not, by definition,